

Course of Theology, Volume IV: On Faith, Hope, and Charity — Disputation VI, Section V

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SECTION V.

Whether it can be certain by Divine faith that this individual Roman Pontiff is the true successor of Peter, and the Vicar of Christ on earth?

147. {marg. Cajetan, Bañez, Alphonsus de Castro deny it.} THE FIRST opinion, the negative, is that of Cajetan 2. 2. q. 1. art. 3. §. *in responsione ad quartum*, of Bañez 2. 2. q. 1. art. 10. in breuioribus commentarijs dub 2. ad 2., of Alphonsus de Castro lib. 1. aduersus hæreses cap. 9., and of others, teaching that it can be held by human prudence alone, or even by infused prudence — beneath which, speculatively, falsehood can lie — that this individual Roman Pontiff is the true successor of Peter, and the Vicar of Christ: although all the things which he proposes as to be believed by Divine faith, we are bound to believe by Divine faith. Their chief foundation is this: that the Canonical election of the Pontiff depends upon many conditions, which not only are we not bound to believe by Divine faith, but we cannot even know in a human way. Therefore it cannot be certain to us by Divine faith that this or that individual Pontiff is the legitimate successor of Peter, and the true Vicar of Christ. The Consequence is evident, because a consequent cannot be certain to us concerning whose antecedent we are in doubt. The Antecedent is established, both as to the conditions prerequired by Divine Law, as that he be a man, Baptized, legitimately ordained; and as to the conditions established by human law, as that he be Canonically elected by legitimate electors, by a sufficient number of ballots, by the will of those voting freely and spontaneously. All of which things we are neither bound to believe by Divine faith, nor can we evidently know in a human way, although upon them depends the legitimate election of Peter's successor to the primacy of the universal Church.

148. It is proved, secondly. Since neither by Scripture, nor by any definition of a true Pontiff, or legitimate tradition, can it be established for us that this singular person is the true successor of Peter. Concerning Scripture, it is evident. Concerning tradition, it is proved, because there is no tradition which obliges the faithful to adore this or that individual Pontiff as the legitimate successor of Peter. {p. 118} Concerning the definition of a true Pontiff, it is plain: for the definition of a true Pontiff supposes a true Pontiff; but if there is uncertainty concerning the singular person of the true Pontiff, the definition concerning his singular person will likewise be uncertain.

149. It is proved, thirdly. He who should deny that this individual Roman Pontiff is the successor of Peter — provided he did not deny that a Roman Pontiff legitimately elected is the successor of Peter — would not be a heretic: therefore, that this individual Roman Pontiff is the true successor of Peter is not of faith: otherwise the opposite would be heretical.

150. Fourthly. If this were of faith concerning one Roman Pontiff, it would be so concerning all who have been raised to the Roman see. But this is not certain by faith concerning all, as is evident from the history of a certain woman who, as Platina relates, by an error of the electors, around the year 850 — or, as others would have it, 873 — was raised to the Chair of Peter, and lived in it two years and five months; who was called John VIII.

151. Fifthly. Even if one incapable be raised to the Roman Chair, it by no means follows either that he will teach anything which Christ did not teach, or that he will define anything against the universal morals of the Church: for either God would never permit him to define anything from the Chair; or at least, in defining matters pertaining to Religion, He would assist him no less than if he were a true Pontiff. Just as both the Church assists a Parish priest, and the commonwealth a Praetor probably reputed such, as is evident from the law *Barbarius* ff. de officio Prætoris.

152. {marg. *Valentia, Suarez, Albertinus, Sylvius more truly affirm it.*} THE SECOND opinion, the affirmative, is that of Valentia disp. 1. quæst. 1. de objecto fidei punct. 7. §. 38., of Suarez de fide disp. 10. sect. 5., of Albertinus principio 3. Philosophico qu. 3. Theologica dubit. 2., of Sylvius lib. 4. de controuers. q. 2. art. 9., and of others. *Which [opinion] is truer and to be followed.* The greatest difficulty is in assigning an efficacious reason.

153. Some assign this one. If it were not established by divine faith that this man is the true Pontiff, neither would it be established by divine faith that this is canonical Scripture, that this is a legitimate Council, that this is Apostolic tradition. For that this is canonical Scripture, that this is a legitimate Council, that this is Apostolic tradition, depends upon the definition and declaration of the Pontiff. Therefore, if it is not certain to me by divine faith that this man is the true Pontiff, neither will it be certain to me by divine faith that this is canonical Scripture, that this is a legitimate Council, that this is Apostolic tradition: and accordingly the whole Christian faith, which rests upon these rules, will collapse.

154. It is confirmed, first. This legitimate Council includes this Pontiff as its true head no less than this proposition, *Christ is a man*, includes his being animal, living thing, substance, &c. But by the same divine faith by which we believe that Christ is a man, we believe that he is animal, living thing, substance: therefore by the same divine faith by which we believe that this Council is legitimate, we believe that this Pontiff is the true head of this Council.

155. It is confirmed, secondly. By the same certitude of faith by which I believe that this object revealed by God is true, I believe that God is of infallible authority in revealing: therefore by the

same certitude of faith by which I believe that this object proposed by the Pontiff is true, I believe that the Pontiff himself is of infallible authority in proposing, since the object, as to its truth, depends no less upon the infallible authority of the one proposing than upon the infallible authority of the one revealing.

156. But to the contrary: for a thing proposed can be certain by divine faith, even though the one proposing be certain not by divine but only by human faith. This is established, first, by examples. For, first, that this is a legitimate Council, convoked by a legitimate head, is established by human faith alone: for it is not immediately applied to us through the Pontiff's own definition, but this is had only through the testimony of the Church, which accepts it as a legitimate Council; which testimony does not exceed human faith: and yet by divine faith we are bound to believe the things which this Council teaches concerning the Orthodox faith. Secondly, that this Scripture has been declared canonical is not established for us immediately by the testimony of the Pontiff defining and declaring that this is canonical Scripture, but by the sole testimony of men, who accept it as such: although nevertheless by divine faith we are bound to believe that it is canonical, and that whatever is contained in it has been revealed by God. Thirdly. We are bound to believe by divine faith that the Mysteries of the Christian Religion are true, and revealed by God, although, that the signs by which they are proposed to us as evidently credible are revealed by God, we believe not by divine faith, but by human. Therefore in like manner we can believe by divine faith the things which this Pontiff proposes to us to be believed, even though by the same divine faith we do not believe that he himself is the true Pontiff.

257. It is proved, secondly, by Reason: since, in order that some object be to be believed by Divine faith, it is not necessary that the proposing of it must be believed by Divine faith, and accordingly that the one proposing must be believed by the same Divine faith; but it suffices if it be believed only by human faith: because it is not necessary that the proposing itself, which only applies the Divine testimony, be itself the testimony of God, since it can be a human testimony rendering evidently credible the Divine testimony itself, which it applies as to be believed. For whenever a thing is proposed as evidently credible that it has been said by God, it obliges one to believe it by divine faith, especially when it is proposed to be believed by the whole Church, since God cannot permit that a thing be proposed to the whole Church as evidently credible, and to be believed on His authority, by whom it has not in fact been said. Since, {p. 119} therefore, the Pontiff stands only as one proposing the things of faith, in order that the things proposed by him be to be believed by Divine faith, it is not necessary that he too be believed by Divine faith to be the true Pontiff; but it suffices if he be believed only by human faith: because, namely, he proposes the thing to be believed with such signs of Pontifical authority that it is morally certain that he is the true Pontiff: for then the thing proposed is to be believed by Divine faith, and yet he himself can be believed by faith only human.

158. Whence the sequel of the argument must be denied: for I can be certain by Divine faith that this is a legitimate Council, that this is Canonical Scripture, that this is Apostolic tradition, even if by the same Divine faith I am not certain that the one proposing is the legitimate Pontiff; but it suffices if I am certain only by human faith.

159. To the former confirmation, the major must be denied: for *Man* includes animal, living thing, substance, as the notes essentially constituting him. Wherefore the same Divine testimony falling upon *Man* falls upon all his essential predicates: and consequently the same assent of the believer which is borne upon Christ as man, is borne upon Christ as animal, as living thing, as substance, which essentially constitute man. But this Council includes this Pontiff only as proposing and declaring that this Council is legitimate: accordingly, not by the same act by which I assent to this Council, that it is legitimate, do I necessarily assent to this Pontiff, that he is the legitimate successor of Peter: but I can by a diverse act assent to the Pontiff as proposing, from one motive, and to the Council as legitimate, from another.

160. YOU WILL SAY. This legitimate Council includes this Pontiff not only as proposing and declaring, but also as an essential part of itself, since it cannot be a legitimate Council except by reason of a legitimate head: therefore, by the very fact that I must believe this to be a legitimate Council, I am bound also to believe that it includes a legitimate head, without which it is not a legitimate Council. I answer concerning the Pontiff as a head included in a legitimate Council below: at present we are impugning only the reason concerning the Pontiff included in a legitimate Council as proposing. For the Pontiff has a twofold respect to the Council: the one, as a head integrating one Mystical body with it; the other, as proposing, and by his authority declaring, that it is legitimate, and that the things which have been defined in it are to be believed by Divine faith — of which alone here.

161. To the latter confirmation, the consequence must be denied. The reason for the difference: because the authority of the one revealing is the very formal motive of faith; for I believe the revealed object on account of the very authority of the one revealing. It is therefore contradictory to believe the revealed object by Divine faith — that is, on account of the authority of God revealing — and at the same time not to believe that God in revealing is of infallible authority, since the infallible Divine authority itself is the very formal motive of believing in Divine faith. But the authority of the Pontiff is not the formal motive by which the thing proposed by him is believed by divine faith, but only a condition prerequisite to believing, which merely applies the thing to be believed. Whence it comes about that we do not, by the same act by which we assent to the things proposed, assent to the one proposing, as by the same act we assent to God revealing, and to the things revealed by Him.

162. You will press. If I am not bound to believe by divine faith that this man, who proposes to me things to be believed by divine faith, is the true Pontiff, it could come about that this man were not the true Pontiff, since falsehood can lie beneath human faith. Which being supposed, this man would

not have, in proposing, the assistance of the Holy Spirit; and consequently he could err: and accordingly falsehood could lie beneath the things proposed by him to be believed by divine faith.

163. I answer by denying the sequel: just as, even though we believe only by human faith the signs of credibility by which the Mysteries of our Religion are proposed, still it cannot come about that things stand otherwise than they are proposed. And the reason is, that although falsehood can lie beneath human testimony taken by itself, yet, taken as it stands under the special providence of God, who uses it for proposing the Mysteries of the Christian Religion, it cannot be false, because as such it is a peculiar instrument of God for persuading the truths that are to be believed on His authority.

164. Others assign this reason. It is impossible that anyone be bound to believe those things which this Pontiff defines as said by God, without being bound also to believe by divine faith that this Pontiff has from God the infallible authority of defining and obliging.

165. But to the contrary: since, as has been shown, in order that I be bound to believe by divine faith the things which the Pontiff defines as said by God, it suffices that through the signs of credibility I believe by human faith that this man has from God the infallible authority of defining and obliging. For by the very fact that through human signs and testimonies it is morally certain to me that this man has the power of defining and obliging from God, I am bound by divine faith to believe the things which he defines as said by God, without my believing by divine faith — but only by human — that he has the power of defining and obliging from God: since it is not necessarily by the same act by which I believe the things proposed by him, that I believe the one proposing.

166. YOU WILL SAY. Therefore I can believe by divine faith the things which this Pontiff proposes to me to be believed, and at the same time doubt concerning the authority of the one proposing, since human faith admits doubt. I answer by denying the consequence: since not every human faith admits doubt. For by human faith I believe that Rome exists, that Aristotle existed; although nevertheless, that Rome exists, or that {p. 120} Aristotle existed, admits no doubt. So too I can believe by human faith that this man is the true Pontiff, and yet admit no doubt concerning this. It is confirmed: for even if I could believe by divine faith, from the divine testimony alone, that this man is the true Pontiff, still it cannot be denied that I can also believe by human faith, from human testimony alone excluding all power of doubting, that this man is the true Pontiff: in which case, no less than in the former, I shall be bound to believe by divine faith the things which he proposes to me to be believed as revealed by God.

167. Others give this reason: whenever the Pontiff either defines something to be believed by divine faith, or establishes something pertaining to the morals of the universal Church, it is to be held of faith that he is the true Pontiff and Vicar of Christ, because God does not permit anything regarding faith, or regarding the morals of the whole Church, to be defined by one who does not have the power of defining from God Himself. But to the contrary: for the things defined by such a Pontiff could pertain to divine faith from this, that they were proposed as to be believed on divine

testimony, with signs of evident credibility that the one proposing is the true Pontiff, even if the Pontiff himself pertained not to the object of divine faith, but of human.

168. {marg. *The true reason.*} These, then, being refuted, two other reasons remain, by which it can be more efficaciously shown that this man is the true Pontiff and successor of Peter. The first is the one we handed down disp. 2. sect. 6. Whenever from one revealed proposition, by an evident deduction, at least moral, another proposition is deduced, such a proposition pertains to faith not as deduced, but as explicated, no less than the immediately revealed proposition itself: which principle we there proved at length. But this proposition — Every Pontiff canonically raised to the Chair of Peter is the true successor of Peter, and Vicar of Christ — is revealed: and from it, by moral evidence, this other can be deduced: this singular man, for example Urban VIII, who now holds the helm of the Church, has been canonically raised to the Chair of Peter: therefore this singular proposition pertains to faith not as deduced, but as explicated. The Minor assumed was proved above, where we showed that the power of governing the Church, which Peter received from Christ, was conferred upon him as to be continued in his successors. The Consequence is evident from the principle adduced: only the Minor is here to be proved, which I prove thus. There can be so many signs of credibility concerning the legitimate election of this man to the Chair of Peter, as to render it morally certain, and, according to the rules of prudence, undoubted: therefore this proposition — this singular man is the legitimate successor of Peter, and Vicar of Christ — can be an object of divine faith. The Consequence is evident, since, in order that some proposition pertain to divine faith, it suffices that it be proposed through such signs as render it morally certain that it has been revealed by God. The Antecedent is proved, because it can at least be evidently established for the electors, by moral evidence, that in the election all the conditions prescribed for a legitimate election were observed. Therefore at least the electors will be bound to adore such a man as the legitimate Vicar of Christ. Then, when the electors promulgate him and propose him to the whole Church to be adored as the legitimate Pontiff, and the true Vicar of Christ and successor of Peter, they sufficiently render morally certain to the others the canonical election of this man to the see of Peter. This moral certitude being in place, the faithful are bound by divine faith to accept him as the legitimate successor of Peter.

169. It is confirmed. No greater moral certitude is had that this is a legitimate Council, than that this man is the legitimate Pontiff: but the moral certitude that this is a legitimate Council suffices to oblige the faithful to accept it by divine faith: Therefore the moral certitude concerning this Pontiff, that he has been legitimately elected, will suffice to oblige the faithful to accept and adore him by divine faith, as the legitimate successor of Peter. The Consequence is evident from parity of reason, against which no disparity can be brought, since each is an object only virtually revealed in sacred Scripture; and each is explicated through moral evidence, and the public testimony of the Church. The Minor is supposed as certain, to be proved below. The Major is shown: for each certitude is moral, depending upon the public faith and testimony of men unanimously attesting it. Nor does it matter that the moral certitude of this legitimate Council depends upon the testimony of more men

than the moral certitude of this legitimate Pontiff — in that the former depends upon the public testimony of the whole Church gathered in a general Council, the latter upon the sole testimony of the Cardinals, which seems private. For, first, not only a general Council, but also a Provincial one declared legitimate by the Pontiff — in which nevertheless the whole Church is not gathered — obliges that it be accepted by divine faith. Secondly, granted that in a general Council there are more persons extensively, they are nevertheless not more intensively: because, since the college of Cardinals was instituted by the whole Church for electing a legitimate Pontiff, the testimony of the Cardinals is the testimony of the whole Church, whose place they bear.

170. YOU WILL SAY. I can have greater moral certitude that this-in-number host has been duly consecrated, or that I have elicited an act of contrition, than that this Pontiff has been legitimately elected: and yet I am not bound to believe by divine faith either that this singular host has been duly consecrated, or that I have elicited a true act of contrition: therefore neither am I bound to believe by divine faith that this Pontiff is the legitimate successor of Peter.

171. I answer by denying the consequence: the reason for the difference is that when a universal proposition is revealed on account of a particular {p. 121} contingent one, concerning which no greater certitude can be had than moral, this suffices for believing it by Divine faith: but that universal proposition, *Every Pontiff legitimately elected is the true successor of Peter, and vicar of Christ*, was revealed to the Church on account of this particular contingent one: *This man is the true successor of Peter and vicar of Christ*: therefore, for believing this by Divine faith there suffices the moral certitude which, according to the rules of prudence, can be had concerning the Canonical election of the Pontiff. The Minor is evident: for the end of this revelation is that in the Church of God there be some infallible animate rule, which, with the assistance of the Holy Spirit, may settle all the controversies which can emerge in her concerning the matter of faith: and this rule, as is evident, must be certain to each one in the individual, to which the faithful may be able to have recourse in doubts of faith. The Major is proved: for otherwise the end of the revelation would be frustrated, if the moral certitude which, according to the rules of prudence, can be had concerning the Canonical election of the Pontiff, did not suffice for believing by Divine faith. On the contrary, that universal proposition, *Every host duly consecrated contains the true body of Christ*, was not revealed for believing by Divine faith that this singular host contains the true body of Christ, but for believing in common that a host duly consecrated contains the true body of Christ. And this because this singular host is not required to be a rule practically directive of morals, as this Pontiff is, but only an object of adoration, for which it suffices that through infused prudence it be apprehended as true, though in the individual it be not true. By like reason, that universal proposition, *Everyone truly contrite is in the grace of God*, was not revealed on account of particular contingents, that this or that man might know himself to be in the grace of God; but only that in common man might know that everyone truly contrite is in the grace of God, so that hereby each may stir himself up to an act of contrition, and at the same time keep himself in holy fear and trembling, not knowing whether he be worthy of hatred or of love.

172. There is also another difference: that the testimony by which the legitimate living rule of the Church is morally certain, is the public testimony of the Church, which is more certain, because God peculiarly assists this testimony, lest the whole Church err: whereas the testimony by which it is rendered morally certain that this host has been duly consecrated, or that this act is true contrition, is private, and exposed to error: nor is God bound by a peculiar providence to assist it, since it does not redound to the error of the whole Church.

173. You will press: this reason supposes that God revealed that universal proposition, *Every Pontiff legitimately elected is the true successor of Peter and vicar of Christ*, on account of this particular one, *This Pontiff has been legitimately elected, and is the true successor of Peter*, as to be believed by Divine faith: but this is in controversy, since the adversaries contend that that universal was revealed only for believing this particular by human faith, not Divine, since this suffices for the office of a practically directing rule.

174. I answer that this is not so much supposed by our reason as proved. For since God's end is, through that revealed universal, to bring into practice this particular, explicated by signs of moral evidence of credibility, just as He obliges that the former be accepted by Divine faith, so also this latter, as soon as it shall have been explicated by signs of moral evidence of credibility. Whence the same Divine testimony which falls upon the universal proposition, falls also upon the particular virtually contained in the universal. And that this is God's end is rightly deduced from this, that this at least conduces better to the function and office of an animate practically directing rule. For thus his decrees and definitions are the more firmly accepted, as to be believed not only on the infallible testimony of God revealing, but also on the infallible authority of the vicar himself proposing. But, in order that this Pontiff be accepted by Divine faith as the legitimate successor of Peter, and vicar of Christ, it is required that his Canonical election be publicly established, and that there be no doubt.

175. {marg. 2. *Reason.*} LET THE SECOND reason be this. By Divine faith we are bound to believe that this is the true Church, that this Council — for example, that of Trent — is legitimate: therefore by Divine faith we are bound to believe that this head, which this-in-number Church includes, and this Pontiff, whom this-in-number legitimate Council includes, is the true Pontiff, and successor of Peter. The Antecedent Catholics admit against the heretics. The Consequence is proved: since this-in-number Church, and this-in-number legitimate Council, includes this-in-number head, without which this-in-number Church, or this-in-number legitimate Council, is not perfect. For just as the Church in common cannot be understood without some head in common by which it is ruled, so this determinate Church, or this determinate legitimate Council, cannot be understood without a determinate head: for this determinate Church, or this determinate legitimate Council, includes this determinate head just as this determinate Physical body includes this determinate Physical head: therefore, just as he who believes that Christ has a determinate Physical body cannot but at the same time believe that Christ has a determinate Physical head, so he who believes that this is a

determinate Church, or that this is a determinate legitimate Council, cannot but at the same time believe that this Church, and this legitimate Council, have a determinate moral head, whereby it Mystically consists.

176. Nor can it be said, first, that this Church, and this legitimate Council, can be believed by Divine faith as to the members only, but not {p. 122} as to the head: because we are bound to believe this Church perfect in the nature of a Church, and this Council perfect and legitimate in the nature of a Council; but neither is the Church perfect, nor the Council legitimate, without a head: therefore, by the same faith by which we are bound to believe that this Church is perfect, and that this Council is legitimate, [we are bound] also to believe that it is with its head.

177. Nor can it be said, secondly, that the members are believed by Divine faith, but the head by human faith: since the same Divine faith obliges us to believe the Church simply, and the legitimate Council simply. Add that, since the Council, as I shall show below, does not have the infallible authority of defining matters of faith except by reason of its head — from which it also has that it be formally legitimate — I cannot believe by Divine faith that it is legitimate, without at the same time believing that it has been gathered under a legitimate head.

178. {marg. *Valentia.*} From what has been said it is deduced that it is established by Divine faith that this Roman Pontiff is the legitimate successor of Peter, and the true vicar of Christ, not only when he either defines something to be believed by Divine faith, or establishes some law, obliging the whole Church, concerning things necessary to salvation, or when through a Jubilee he exercises the juridical act of dispensing the treasury of the Church, as Valentia teaches; but also even before any juridical act proper to the Pontiff, provided that his Canonical election be morally certain and undoubted among the faithful.

179. {marg. *Reply to the foundations of the 1st opinion.*} {marg. *To the 1st.*} To the foundation of the 1st opinion, it must be conceded that the Canonical election of this Pontiff depends upon many conditions: yet it must be denied that, if it be morally certain, and be publicly accepted as such by the Church, it can be invalid through the defect of some Condition: not that God, even if it should fail in some condition, would accept it as legitimate, and afford His assistance: but because He will never permit that one be held, and received by the whole Church, as legitimate, who is not in fact legitimate: and this upon the supposition that He willed that we should believe this man to be the legitimate successor of Peter, and His own true Vicar, as was proved above. Whence, by the very fact that he is accepted as the legitimate Pontiff, all the conditions, both of Divine and of Ecclesiastical law, are supposed to have been observed in him.

180. {marg. *To the 2nd.*} To the 2nd, I answer that this truth is established for us from sacred scripture, as explicated through the moral evidence which is established for the Church through certain signs of the credibility of the Canonical election. For through these it is explicated that that power of feeding the sheep, conferred upon Peter and his successors, is found in this singular

person, in whom is found moral evidence and certitude concerning his legitimate succession into the see of Peter.

181. {marg. *To the 3rd.*} To the 3rd, I answer that this comes from this, that, although this our opinion is of faith, yet it is not so certain that it is of faith, that the opposite could be convicted of open heresy.

181. {marg. *To the 4th.*} To the 4th, the sequel must be conceded concerning those with regard to whose legitimate election as Pontiff it was certainly established; otherwise concerning those with regard to whose legitimate election it was not certainly established. But that history of the woman raised to the Pontificate Cardinal {marg. *Bellarmino.*} Bellarmine learnedly refutes, lib. 3. de Romano Pontifice cap. vlt.

183. {marg. *To the 5th.*} To the 5th, I answer that neither assigned way suffices. Not the first: both because, by the very fact that the Canonical election of the Roman Pontiff is morally established with certainty, the testimony of Christ — obliging us to believe by Divine faith that all the successors of Peter receive from Him the power of ruling the Church — obliges us to believe that this man is the successor of Peter, as was proved above: and because, granted he were not permitted either to define anything pertaining to faith, or to establish anything regarding the universal morals of the Church, or to exercise any juridical act of the supreme Pastor, yet this itself would be violent, and against the sweet order of Divine providence. For this man could live long, and, according to the laws of Ecclesiastical Government, the occasion could frequently recur of exercising some juridical act proper to the Pontiff, which in an event of this kind would be too violently impeded.

184. Not the second: for it is false that the infallible assistance of the Holy Spirit is given to a Pontiff not Canonically elected: since we gather it from no other source than from the promise made to Peter, upon whom it was conferred only as upon a legitimate Pontiff instituted by Christ. Therefore we ought not rashly to extend it also to those not legitimately elected: since neither authority nor reason urges this. Nor is the reasoning the same concerning a human superior, who, since he is not of such power as to be always able to provide the Commonwealth with true and legitimate Ministers, in order to avoid greater absurdities, legitimates the acts performed by ministers only probably reputed such. But God, since He can always provide His Church with a legitimate Pastor, it must rather be said that He will never permit that one incapable be elected to the Chair of Peter, than that, this being permitted, He will legitimate all his acts: since the former is more connatural, and more congruent with the power and wisdom of God; whereas the latter would argue a defect of power not availing to provide the Church with a legitimate Minister: Whence, if human superiors could, they would choose the former rather than the latter.